from Arabia. Muhammad al-Wahhab's story is well known: how he formed an alliance with a minor tribal Bedouin chief that led ultimately to the founding of the Wahhabi-based kingdom of Saudi Arabia, and, from 1979 onwards, the widespread export of that fundamentalist creed very largely thanks to Saudi Arabia's petro-dollars. Shah Waliullah's legacy in South Asia is barely known about in non-Muslim India, let alone in the West, but has been equally far-reaching.[11]

Shah Waliullah returned to his father's seminary in Delhi, Madrassa-i-Rahimiya, and from there set out to reform Islam in India. In 1760 he wrote to the new ruler of Afghanistan Ahmad Shah Durrani, calling on him to return India to Islam. Ahmad Shah duly took up the invitation, leading to the battlefield of Panipat, north of Delhi, where over a hundred and fifty thousand Hindu Maratha warriors are said to have died. This was a catastrophe for the Marathas, who were by now masters of Western India and had been poised to take control of Northern India. The disaster at Panipat cleared the way for the EICo to extend its rule beyond Bengal and Bombay, and in South India it allowed Hyder Ali and his son Tipu Sahib to expanded the territories of Mysore.

Hyder Ali claimed descent from the Prophet Muhammad's Quareshi tribe but was more likely a descendant of one of the many Afghans who had followed the Mughals into India. As an officer in the army of the Hindu raja of Mysore, he had shown himself to be so capable a leader that he was given command of the army, after which it was only a small step to ruling Mysore in the raja's name. He then set out to secure control of the Malabar country with its coastal ports and its profitable spice plantations. North Malabar was won in 1766 and Cochin a year later, but Hyder Ali and his equally capable son Tipu then found themselves constantly at war with the Nairs, whose obstinacy they met with ever-increasing brutality. Hyder's determination to ally himself